

Fear, Sadness, and Anger

When I awoke that day I already had a deep, sinking feeling. It was as if something sinister were twisting my chest into a knot.

Things had seemed incredibly dire the night before, so I already had a good idea of what to expect. Yet, part of me hoped beyond hope that my fears would be proven wrong. The very first thing I did was grab my phone and open Google. When I saw that my fears had come true while I slept, my heart sank into the abyss.

I took a moment to compose myself as best as I could. I took some deep breaths in and out, laid back in my bed for a moment, then sat up.

The next thing I did was text my parents and my friends to see how they were feeling. I paid extra care to some specific friends, as I was deeply worried for their immediate mental safety, as well as their physical safety in the months and years that loomed ahead. Their very right to exist was at stake, so I pushed my own feelings aside for a brief moment. I may have been afraid for myself as well, but my fear for them trumped that.

The message I sent out to everyone was simple and direct: "How are you feeling?"

One of the first people to respond was one of my transgender friends, who told me she felt like throwing up.

I quickly responded: "Yeah that makes sense, im scared for yall. If u want someone to talk to just let me know, im here for what its worth."

My parents also responded to me quickly. They told me they were taking it pretty bad as well, as I expected, but offered me a bit of comfort.

Of course, I told them I was fine.

Of course, I rather was not fine, and I knew that they knew that. Yet, they accepted my answer, because they knew too. In that moment, we understood each other better than perhaps ever before.

The third thing I did was email my professors for the day that I wasn't going to be attending class. There was no way my heart would be in it, and I desperately felt the need to do nothing except recharge that day. I needed to get ahold of myself, and going to class was not an option. I told them exactly why I was going to be absent, and my professors were okay with it.

In fact, one of my professors had already sent out a direct message to all of his students telling us that he decided to cancel for the day. I sent him a message as well, saying:

“That makes sense. I hope you feel better and get any mental help you need. I'm in a rough place too, so sending best wishes.”

He responded with: “Hey, thank you! We shall endure...”

Once the messages were sent, I put on my headphones and listened to Pink Floyd's *Wish You Were Here* for a while in bed. I closed my eyes and let the notes wash over me, bathing me in their healing power. The lyrics, dripped in melancholy and regret, soothed my soul in that trying time.

Wish You Were Here helped me through hard times back in freshman year of college, so it was only natural I would turn to it when I was in such great distress yet again. The gentle melancholy melody of the music soothed me. For but a moment, it made me feel like things could be okay. It made me feel like I was not alone. As the music played, however, I felt a sense of dread creeping closer and closer to my heart.

Eventually I got out of bed and started the day for real. My whole body felt heavy, and my head simultaneously felt completely blank and seemed to be running a mile a

minute. I didn't know what to do with myself as I dragged my body out of bed, but I knew I needed to get something to eat.

I don't think breakfast tasted like anything that day. I think I simply ate out of necessity. No comfort was provided by the food, and my mind kept running at full speed as I ate, with no sign of stopping any time soon. Yet, my mind was so focused on other things that there was no room left for the food, except to mindlessly shovel macaroni into my mouth and chew.

Once the sadness had subsided I was left with seething rage. When I spoke with my roommate about the results we shared in our anger. Then I went on Discord to share my anger with my friends online.

Images of children lying on the ground, dead and mutilated, flashed through my mind. I remembered pictures of fully grown people, reduced to living skeletons by starvation. Those sorts of image had shown up countless times on my social media feed for about a year at that point, and they had a noticeable effect on me. That day, with a heart full of resentment, I thought to myself:

"Yesterday, I acted *despite that*. I compromised my morals, and *for what?! I chose to support the 'lesser evil', yet the 'greater evil' still succeeded. Now, all I am left with is my guilt. Guilt that I betrayed those dead children for absolutely nothing. Guilt that I betrayed myself.*"

We all felt the anger, yet we all knew what lurked beneath it as well. Underneath the anger, threatening to bubble over at any moment, we were confused and so terribly scared.

I was scared for my friends who were especially vulnerable, who were at risk of being punished for the crime of being themselves. They were staring down the barrel of the coming years with determination that merely served to hide their own fear and

confusion. At the same time, that they kept moving forward, despite everything, gave me no small amount of strength.

I was scared for my parents who would do everything in their power to support people like my friends and may yet suffer because of it. I worried that even supporting me may prove difficult, or that their own fear may take them. My mom had always had health issues, so I worried that they would only get worse in light of the recent news. Indeed, I was right to be worried, because in the time since then I fear my mom has had a great decline in her mental health. There is nothing to do except to keep moving forwards.

I was scared for myself, even though I knew I was privileged enough to get through it – something that I knew was not true for some of the people I cared deeply about.

Later that evening I played *Elden Ring* for hours. Similar to *Wish You Were Here*, *Elden Ring* is something near and dear to my heart that had helped me get through difficult times, so I was eager to latch onto it for help once again.

I had played the game countless times, so that night I ran through the motions of things that were familiar to me. As I played, as I stared into the screen of my laptop, I felt my mind dissociating. I was trying to avoid thinking of anything real, instead choosing to absorb myself in the game because it gave me comfort – it let me forget, if only for a time; I knew that ignoring the problem wouldn't work in the long-term, but that night I let the game carry my thoughts away to someplace nicer, someplace where I didn't have to worry about the safety of my friends and family; I had already worried so much that night, I had nothing left in me.

I knew that I had much to worry about in the coming years anyway, all the time in the world to dwell on the horrible things that were about to unfold. Why not let my mind wander into nothingness for one evening, before it all begins?

I should probably mention that I was, and tragically still remain, single. I have only held a single romantic relationship in my life, and that was back near the very beginning of high school.

Normally, this doesn't bother me too terribly. It certainly does bother me, but not in any way that impacts me heavily.

Yet, I think that day it did matter to me. I felt a distinct lack of companionship.

I had my friends, I had my family, yet part of me felt that if I just had *someone* there, by my side, to comfort me as I comforted them, that it would be a great balm on my soul.

As it happens, thinking about that which I lacked just made me feel even worse.

I fear dinner was hardly any different than breakfast. I doubt I even ate lunch.

The memory of my muscles carried me as I mechanically devoured my Jimmy John's sandwich. Two pieces of bread, one layer of turkey, one layer of cheese, and four packets worth of mayonnaise. On a normal day, I would take great joy in how abjectly horrifying my Jimmy John's regular is, but there was no joy to be had in it that day. I merely consumed, like the macaroni earlier.

Once my mind returned to the earth somewhat, I joined a Discord call with my friends. I wanted to speak to them, to hear their voices, to take comfort in the presence of the ones I held so much worry for. At the same time, however, I felt like I still didn't want to face reality head-on like I had that morning.

As we talked, I continued playing Elden Ring. I was playing on the same laptop I was calling my friends on, leaning back in my chair while clutching my green controller in my hands. By splitting my attention between the discussion and the game, I was still

able to let some of my thoughts frolic in a happier place. A place that felt so, so far away earlier in the day. Even just a sliver of joy felt like a shower of sunlight to me then.

My friends and I spoke of the results. We discussed how they had come about, and we vented our worries and fears about what was going to change. I told them I was here for them, and they assured me that they were there for me, too. I was, and still am, endlessly thankful to them.

I fought my way through the Academy of Raya Lucaria and defeated a boss I had already felled over a dozen times before. My mastery over the game made me feel like I was in control. It made me happy beyond words that there was at least something I was in control of, even if it held no importance to anything, relatively speaking.

My mind bounced between these two realities. By remaining present in both at the same time, I think I kept myself sane.

Later that night, once the Discord call was long gone, I found myself scrolling through YouTube. I often do that when I'm bored. I also frequently scroll thorough Twitter (I will never call it X) when bored as well, but that night I could not bring myself to look at that website in particular.

Looking through YouTube, refreshing my home page every other minute, nothing seemed interesting to watch. Nothing felt *compelling*. Every time I considered watching a video, the very idea seemed to disgust me. Whenever I did finally settle on something to watch I got bored, opened Twitter on my phone, then quickly closed it once I realized my error.

It felt like I was in purgatory.

I felt nothing, I couldn't settle on something to distract myself with, and I would feel nothing for the rest of the night. I felt myself growing tired, yet I avoided going to bed. Yet, staying awake provided naught but boredom.

Eventually, I opened up Elden Ring again. After a couple dozen minutes, even that lost my interest. That caused me to officially give up and climb back up into my dorm bunk bed. The bright green sheets, with magenta sheets peeked out from underneath them, reminded me of home. That made me feel happy, even if only a little bit.

That night I slept poorly. I regularly have trouble falling asleep, due to my terrible allergies keeping me up, making it difficult for me to breathe through my clogged nostrils. That night was worse than most. I closed my eyes and tried to think of nothing, but it was useless. I could not stop the thoughts from plaguing me incessantly. When there was nothing to distract me, the feelings threatened to overtake me – to devour me. The anger, the sadness, the confusion, the anxiety, the worry, and the fear claimed my every thought.

As I failed to fall asleep, I looked again at the long-winded message I sent in Discord earlier that day, when my anger was still boiling:

“I am very angry.

I am angry at the Republicans, because I know what type of regime they want to run. I know that it is going to be worse than in 2016, especially with them controlling all 3 branches of the government this time around. I am angry about what their victory means for my friends, for me, and for the country.

I am angry at the voters who voted for them. It truly hurts to know that we live in a country where so many people would choose to cast their vote for this fascist dipshit.

And lastly, I am angry at the Democratic party, for being so fucking useless. This election could have been won, it potentially could have been a landslide, but they just couldn't get it the fuck together. I didn't feel good voting for them, and I imagine that's why many people didn't vote for them at all. But I do not want to blame the people who didn't vote for the Democrats – only the people who did vote for the Republicans. The

Democrats ran a useless fucking campaign and they lost to Trump for the second time – this time they lost the popular vote too!

The Republicans are fucking dumb, the Democrats are fucking dumb, and this country is fucking dumb. Did I miss anything?”

I quickly accepted that I wasn’t going to be able to sleep at a normal time, but that was fine. I wasn’t planning on going to class the next day either.

As I had thought, the next day I didn’t feel much better. I emailed my professors again that I would be absent. They were as understanding as ever, which I am thankful for.

As I ate breakfast reality began to truly sink in. I suppose I had reached acceptance, in a way. I felt... numb, sort of. At the very least I knew I would be able to go to class tomorrow, though the week was nearly over.

I stared at my computer screen, and my body felt stiff, unmoving and unresponsive. Almost as if it didn’t want to keep moving at all. Yet, I knew that above all else, I needed to keep moving forwards.

One truth that still rang clear in my head was that the next four years were going to be very difficult, and painfully long. If my friends, family, and I wanted to get through it, we would need to find a way to move forwards together. I knew that as long as we kept pushing onwards, all hope would not be lost.

You just need to cry until your tears stop flowing, scream until your throat can’t take it...

...and just keep pushing forwards.